Local AI Assistant for Architects

Practical time-savers you can run locally (no coding required to use)

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This handout shows realistic ways a local AI assistant can save time in an architecture workflow. The best wins come from writing, searching, and coordination (high volume, text-heavy tasks), not from automatically producing drawings or replacing professional judgement.

What's possible (use cases)

These are common, practical use cases. You can start small and add more over time.

- Meeting -> minutes: decisions, action items (owners + due dates), and follow-up emails.

- Project Q&A ('Ask my project'): search across specs, PDFs, notes, and emails with citations.

- Drafting: RFIs, site reports, consultant emails, agendas, scope summaries.

- Weekly 'open loops' report: what's unanswered, blocking, or waiting on others.

- Submittal/RFI summarization: highlight what changed and what needs a decision.

- Code/standards helper: answer questions from your local code PDFs with referenced excerpts.

- Consistency checks (text-based): detect contradictions between spec sections / schedules / notes.

- Knowledge library: find similar past decisions/details by searching prior project folders.

- Client-ready summaries: turn technical notes into a clear client update.

- Internal onboarding: 'How we do this' quick guides based on your office standards.

The best 5 to implement first (and why)

These five usually deliver the highest payoff with the lowest risk. They also help build a clean project record.

1) Meeting minutes + actions

- Why: immediate time savings; fewer missed tasks; clearer coordination.

- How: paste notes/transcript -> get minutes + decisions + action list -> send follow-ups.

- What's required: a consistent template + a place to store meeting notes (folder per project).

2) ’Ask my project’ document search (with citations)

- Why: reduces time lost searching across PDFs and email threads.
- How: keep a ’Project Vault’ folder -> ask questions -> AI answers with quoted sources.
- What’s required: exported PDFs/emails/notes + a simple index so the AI can retrieve the right pages.

3) Draft RFIs / site reports / consultant emails

- Why: avoids blank-page writing and keeps tone/format consistent.
- How: pick a template -> provide a few bullets -> AI produces a clean first draft.
- What’s required: your preferred templates (1-2 examples is enough to start).

4) Weekly ’open loops’ summary

- Why: keeps projects moving; prevents small items from slipping.
- How: AI scans meeting actions + RFIs + notes -> produces a single list of outstanding items.
- What’s required: store actions consistently (even in a simple list) and tag who owns what.

5) Code/standards Q&A (local ’code librarian’)

- Why: faster lookups; improves consistency; reduces rework.
- How: ask a question -> get an answer + cited excerpts from your local code documents.
- What’s required: the code PDFs you use (and permission to store them locally).

Realistic expectations (what’s harder)

- Reading drawing sheets visually (plans/sections/callouts) reliably from PDFs is harder and less consistent.
- Deep Revit/ArchiCAD automation usually needs dedicated plugins and careful testing.
- AI should support decisions, not make them - citations and review are essential.

What a basic setup looks like (no jargon)

- A ’Project Vault’ folder with subfolders: 01_Admin, 02_Notes, 03_Specs, 04_RFIs, 05_Submittals.
- A small habit: drop key PDFs/exports into the vault and keep meeting notes in one place.

- A local AI app that can: (1) draft text, and (2) search your vault and cite sources.

Questions to tailor this to your workflow

- What tools do you use daily? (Revit/ArchiCAD, Bluebeam, Outlook/Gmail, Teams/Zoom, etc.)
- Where do you lose the most time: searching, writing, coordination, or QA checks?
- Which documents are most common for you: RFIs, site reports, meeting minutes, specs, submittals?
- Do you work solo or as a team (shared standards and shared project folders)?
- Any confidentiality constraints that require everything to stay on your machine?
- What would success look like in 2-3 weeks? (e.g., save 2 hours/week; fewer missed actions)